

Area of Study 3A – Catholic Christianity

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Catholic Christianity as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, with specific regard to philosophy of religion and issues of equality and social justice.

There are four sections: Catholic Beliefs, Philosophy of Religion, Living the Catholic Life and Equality.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Catholics today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how the Bible informs a Catholic's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Catholic Christianity within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Catholic Christianity with wider Christian perspectives as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.8)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.2)*

Students should recognise that Catholic Christianity is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Catholic Christianity with wider Christian perspectives and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Catholic Christianity there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within the wider Christian tradition in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Orthodox, Protestant and other Christian traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The Trinity: the nature and significance of the Trinity as expressed in the Nicene Creed; the nature and significance of the oneness of God; the nature and significance of each of the Persons individually: God as the Father, Son and Holy Spirit; how this is reflected in worship and belief in the life of a Catholic today.
1.2	Biblical understandings of God as a Trinity of Persons: the nature and significance of God as a Trinity of Persons, including reference to the baptism of Jesus (Matthew 3:13–17); the historical development of the doctrine of the Trinity, including reference to the First Council of Nicaea and the First Council of Constantinople.
1.3	Creation: the nature and significance of the biblical account of Creation, including Genesis 1–3; and how it may be understood in divergent ways in Christianity, including reference to literal and metaphorical interpretations; the significance of the Creation account for Catholics in understanding the nature and characteristics of God, especially as Creator, benevolent, omnipotent and eternal.
1.4	The significance of the Creation account in understanding the nature of humanity: the nature and significance of the nature of humanity being created in the image of God, including reference to Genesis 1–3 and divergent understandings of humanity’s relationship with Creation (dominion and stewardship); the implications of these beliefs for Catholics today.
1.5	The Incarnation: Jesus as incarnate Son, the divine Word, both fully God and fully human; the scriptural origins of this belief, including John 1:1–18 and its importance for Catholics today.
1.6	The events in the Paschal Mystery: Catholic teachings about the life, death, resurrection and ascension of Jesus, including reference to Luke 24; the redemptive efficacy of these events and their significance for Catholics today.
1.7	The significance of the life, death, resurrection and ascension of Jesus for Catholic beliefs about salvation and grace, including John 3:10–21 and Acts 4:8–12; the implications and significance of these events for Catholic practice today.
1.8*	Catholic beliefs about eschatology: life after death; the nature of resurrection, judgement, heaven, hell and purgatory, including reference to John 11:17–27 and 2 Corinthians 5:1–10; divergent Christian beliefs about life after death, with reference to purgatory and the nature of resurrection; why belief in life after death is important for Catholics today.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Revelation as proof of the existence of God: the significance of Jesus Christ as the culmination of God's revelation; what the revelation of Jesus Christ shows about the nature of God for Catholics, including reference to Hebrews 1:1–4.
2.2	Visions as proof of the existence of God: the nature and importance of visions for Catholics; biblical and non-biblical examples of visions, including Joan of Arc and Genesis 15 and Matthew 17:1–13; reasons why they might lead to belief in God, and Catholic responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that visions are hallucinations and provide no proof that God exists; divergent understandings of what visions show about the nature of God for Catholics.
2.3	Miracles as proof of the existence of God: the nature and importance of miracles for Catholics; biblical and non-biblical examples of miracles including those at Lourdes and John 4:43–54; reasons why they might lead to belief in God and Catholic responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist), which maintain that miracles can be scientifically explained and provide no proof that God exists; divergent understandings of what miracles show about the nature of God for Catholics.
2.4	Catholic attitudes towards religious experiences and their use as philosophical arguments for the existence of God: the nature of religious experience and why not all religious experiences are approved by the Church, including reference to Catechism of the Catholic Church 66–67; Catholic responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments that religious experiences do not provide proof that God exists.
2.5	Design argument: the classical design argument for the existence of God and its use by Catholics as a philosophical argument for the existence of God; divergent understandings about what the design argument shows about the nature of God for Catholics, including Romans 1:18–24; Catholic responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the design argument as evidence for the existence of God.
2.6	Cosmological argument: the cosmological argument for the existence of God and its use by Catholics as a philosophical argument for the existence of God, including reference to Thomas Aquinas' First Three Ways of showing God's existence; divergent understandings of the nature and importance of what the cosmological argument shows about the nature of God for Catholics; Catholic responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the cosmological argument as evidence for the existence of God.
2.7	Issues raised by the existence of suffering and God as all-loving: the issues it raises for Catholics about the nature of God, including Isaiah 45; how the problem and its basis as a philosophical argument may lead some to examine and others to reject their belief in God.
2.8	The solutions offered to the problem of suffering and a loving and righteous God within Catholicism: biblical, theoretical and practical responses – Psalms, including reference to Psalm 119, Job, free will (St Augustine), as a way for humans to develop (St Irenaeus), prayer, and charity; divergent understandings within Christianity of their success in solving the problem.

Students should have an understanding of

3.1	The sacramental nature of reality: Catholic teachings about how the whole of creation manifests the presence of God; the meaning and effects of each of the seven sacraments, including Catechism of the Catholic Church 1210–1211; the practice and symbolism of each sacrament; how sacraments communicate the grace of God; divergent Christian attitudes to sacraments, including reference to Orthodox and Protestant Christianity.
3.2*	Liturgical worship within Catholic Christianity: the nature and significance of the Mass for Catholics, including its structure and the Eucharist as the 'source and summit of Christian life' with reference to Lumen Gentium paragraph 7; divergent Christian attitudes towards the practice and meaning of liturgical worship, including its significance for Catholics and the less structured worship in evangelical Christian denominations.
3.3	The funeral rite as a liturgical celebration of the Church: practices associated with the funeral rite in the home, the church and the cemetery, including reference to 'Preparing my funeral' by Vincent Nichols, Archbishop of Westminster; the aims of the funeral rite, including communion with the deceased; the communion of the community and the proclamation of eternal life to the community and its significance for Catholics.
3.4	Prayer as the 'raising of hearts and minds to God': the nature and significance of different types of prayer; the Lord's Prayer, including Matthew 6:5–14, set (formulaic) prayers and informal (extempore) prayer; when each type might be used and why; the importance of prayer and the importance for Catholics of having different types of worship.
3.5	The role and importance of forms of popular piety: the nature and significance of of the Rosary, Eucharistic adoration and Stations of the Cross; how each of these might be used and why; the importance of having different types of worship for Catholics, including reference to Catechism of the Catholic Church 1674–1676; divergent Christian attitudes to these forms of piety.
3.6	Pilgrimage: the nature, history and purpose of Catholic pilgrimage; the significance of the places people go on pilgrimage; divergent Christian understandings about whether pilgrimage is important for Christians today, with specific reference to Jerusalem, Lourdes, Rome, Walsingham and the Catechism of the Catholic Church 2691–2696.
3.7	Catholic Social Teaching: how Catholic Social Teaching reflects the teaching to show love of neighbour; Catholic teaching on justice, peace and reconciliation, Evangelii Gaudium paragraphs 182–237 – The inclusion of the poor in society; how these teachings might be reflected in the lives of individual Catholics, including reference to Matthew 25:31–46 (the Parable of the Sheep and Goats); the work of CAFOD, what it does and why.
3.8	Catholic mission and evangelism: the history and significance of mission and evangelism for Catholics; divergent ways this is put into practice by the Church and individual Catholics locally, nationally and globally, and how this fulfils the commission of Jesus and teachings of the Church, including Evangelii Gaudium Chapter 5.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Catholic teaching on human rights: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature, history and purpose of human rights; the importance of human rights and why Catholics might support them, including The Common Good and the Catholic Church's Social Teaching 36–37; divergent Christian responses to the need for and application of individual human rights, including the support offered by situation ethics; Catholic responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments about human rights.
4.2	Catholic attitudes towards equality: Catholic teachings, responses and solutions to the causes of inequality and problems caused by inequality in the world; Catholic teachings about equality, including reference to interpretations of John 13:34.
4.3	Catholic attitudes towards religious freedom: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature of religious freedom, including reference to the Catechism of the Catholic Church 1738 and 1747; the response of the Catholic Church to a multi-faith society; the benefits and challenges for Catholics living in a multi-faith society; Catholic responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) against aspects of religious freedom.
4.4	Catholic attitudes to prejudice and discrimination: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature of prejudice and discrimination and the problems they cause, including links to situation ethics; Catholic teachings on why prejudice and discrimination against religions is wrong, including reference to Catechism of the Catholic Church 1934–1935.
4.5	Catholic attitudes towards racial harmony: Catholic teachings and responses to the teachings of the Catholic Church about racial harmony and those that may reflect ethical theories, such as situation ethics; how and why Catholics have worked for racial harmony, including Galatians 3:23–29; the benefits for Catholics of living in a multi-ethnic society.
4.6	Catholic attitudes towards racial discrimination: Catholic teachings and responses to racial discrimination, how and why racial discrimination causes problems in society, including reference to Acts 17:22–28.
4.7	Catholic attitudes to social justice: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature and history of the distribution of wealth and opportunity in the UK and the world; Catholic teaching about social justice, and the way the Church works for social justice, including reference to Catechism of the Catholic Church 1928–1933; links to situation ethics and Catholic responses to them.
4.8	Catholic attitudes towards wealth and poverty: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature and causes of poverty in the UK and in the world, including absolute and relative; Catholic teachings about wealth and poverty, including biblical examples such as Matthew 25:31–47 and links to virtue ethics.